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THE SMART CITY IS HUMAN



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The convergence of the BRICS and G20 agendas in 2025, under South Africa's theme of Solidarity, Equality, and Sustainability, offers a pivotal moment to redefine what "smart infrastructure" means for the Global South. As discussions on inclusive growth, food security, and the governance of Artificial Intelligence (AI) take centre stage, our understanding of urban development must return to its most vital layer: people and their everyday spaces.

Africa's evolving smart infrastructure cannot be built solely on imported, capital-intensive technologies. Such approaches risk creating digitally advanced enclaves that exacerbate the inequalities the G20 aims to address. True smart infrastructure must be rooted in inclusive urbanism and climate-resilient planning, recognising the ingenuity already present in African urban life.

Re-engineering the smart city from the ground up

African cities, from Cape Town to Addis Ababa, already possess sophisticated, people-driven systems. Informal networks, walking cultures, and community-led spatial practices function as living infrastructure that connect traditional urban forms with modern governance. The future of smart cities lies in supporting these human-scale systems; decentralising innovation, improving accessibility, and using community-based research to understand how people actually use space.

Resilient cities emerge when digital tools strengthen these existing systems rather than replace them. For Africa, the "smart city" must also be the just city – one where technology serves equality, mobility, and social connection.

Governance and digital transformation

The G20's focus on AI and data governance is directly tied to infrastructure justice. As African cities pursue digital transformation, new governance frameworks must ensure that data serves equality rather than surveillance or exclusion. Policy must ask: Are we using technology to enhance everyday life, or to reinforce existing divides?

Transparent, community-driven decisions about public space, mobility, and digital access are essential. Technology should bridge gaps, not create new ones.

A people-centred vision for Africa's urban future

Smart cities in Africa must act as engines for inclusive growth and sustainable industrialisation. The New Development Bank and other multilateral actors should prioritise investments that strengthen local, climate-responsive infrastructure and expand equitable access to digital tools.

For South Africa's G20 Presidency, placing Africa's development at the top of the agenda means recognising that the most successful smart city is one where technology disappears into the background, where life, commerce, and community thrive with greater solidarity, equality, and sustainability.

The path to a resilient Global South is built not only with fibre-optic cables but also with sidewalks, public spaces, and the shared vision of a just urban future.